massacre of their troops was being openly discussed in the bazaar, ‘recommending me strongly to spend the winter in Kabul’, Pottinger became convinced that another major uprising was about to break out.[21] But Macnaghten refused either to listen to his worries or to send him the reinforcements or the artillery that he believed would be necessary if he were to hold his position. So Pottinger spent weeks collecting more intelligence and then forwarded a second, more detailed assessment to Macnaghten. The Kohistan chiefs, he wrote, had initially supported Shah Shuja, but found that the strictness of the Anglo-Sadozai administration ‘was inimical to their interests and power insomuch that it had given them a master who was able to compel obedience instead of one who was obliged to overlook their excesses’. In addition there were other reasons for revolt: ‘Hatred of foreign domination, fanaticism, the licentiousness of our troops, and particularly the impunity with which women could be seduced and carried off in a country celebrated for the extreme jealousy of the natives . . .’ He went on:

> The enemies of the British are increasing in their endeavours to blacken our character, prejudice the populace against us and encourage outlaws. During July and August, while the crops were on the ground, burning of stacks and cutting the banks of the irrigating canals were of frequent occurrence and constant inroads were made by parties of outlaws, without the royal authorities being able to arrest them, even though it was evident that many of the people were cognizant of their comings and goings . . . Nearly every hour brings rumours of the formation of an extensive conspiracy . . . and I feel it my duty to recommend that hostages be demanded from the Kohistan Chiefs.[22]

The reality was that resistance was growing everywhere against the British, and only in Kabul itself was there still some support for the Anglo-Sadozai regime. Even there the popularity of Shuja was crumbling. According to Maulana Kashmiri:

> The people were oppressed by the violence of the Firangi
> They were afflicted by the arrogance of the Firangi
>
> No vestige of honour remained in the city
> Law and order had no standing
>
> The Khans were so disgraced
> Like earth they mixed with water
>
> When in this way Kabul was terror-struck